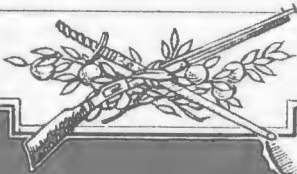


SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA



San Luis Obispo



Guadalupe Santa Maria

SANTA BARBARA

Lompoc Santa Inez Salvans Mission

Santa Barbara Montecito

Ojai Fillmore Santa Paul Saticoy Ventura Montalvo Oxnard Silver Strand Malibu Beach

Nikelela Santa Rosa Santa Cruz







COUNTRY OF THE SUN



SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA
AN INFORMAL HISTORY AND GUIDE

By Scott O'Dell



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team of *nuqueadores*, armed with short knives, quietly circulated among them. A swift jab of the knife at the nape of the neck, and the steer dropped like a stone. As more and more were felled, those remaining grew restless, and finally bolted in every direction. Yelling and brandishing their knives in a frenzy of excitement, the various *nuqueadores* pursued each animal, ranged alongside of it, though the chase might take them far afield, and striking down, delivered the killing blow. It was a dangerous business, but a popular one on all the ranches.

After the slaughter, a squad, usually of Indian women, cut up the tallow and piled it on the hides, which were folded and dragged off to the trying vats. Melted and properly cooled, the fat was poured into *botas* fashioned of green skins, which when filled made a standard weight of five hundred pounds, worth from twenty to forty dollars, depending upon the year.

The tallow and hides were then stacked in two-wheeled *carretas* pulled by oxen, and delivered to the headland at Dana Point, or to the beach, as at Ventura, for the ship to load and carry to the drying yards in San Diego.

3. *The Lost Woman of San Nicholas*

Mission San Buenaventura was given over to the secular authorities in 1836; the gardens and orchards quickly disappeared, and the mission lands were parceled out to friends of the administrator. New ranchos and old thrived on plentiful rain, tall grass, and good prices, untouched by the war, until the depression and drought of the early sixties. Lands in the Santa Clara, Ojai, and San Buenaventura Valleys then were taken up by eastern capitalists bent upon finding oil.

In 1866 the town of San Buenaventura was incorporated and the first schoolhouse built. At Saticoy and Santa Paula, ranches were subdivided into small farms. The days of the dons were over. The land boom was on.

It was accelerated by the coming of the stagecoach. Travelers from San Diego and Los Angeles and San Francisco no longer had to arrive by horseback or on the occasional sailing ships that anchored at Ventura. Six-horse equipages rolled smartly into

the town by way of the Simi, Conejo, and Santa Clara Valleys. From Ventura to Santa Barbara, matters were somewhat different. The road followed the beach, and at certain points the stage was forced to run hub-deep in the surf, often to wait until the tide had gone out before proceeding up the coast.

Ventura County was formed in 1873, by cutting off the southeasterly corner of Santa Barbara County, and the name shortened to "Ventura," though the county seat was still called San Buenaventura. Corralled by the new county were also two islands: Anacapa and San Nicholas.

Anacapa, a barren mesa rising steeply from the sea, where birds nested and sea lions sported among innumerable caves, was a haunt of the Chumash Indians, who sped across the channel in their canoes to snare birds and gather shellfish. They always returned.

In later years sheep were pastured on the eastern half of the island, foraging among the succulent, low-growing ice plants for both food and water. Latterly, it has housed a powerful synchronized beacon to warn and guide ships sailing the coastal lanes.

It was this waterless island that indirectly changed the course of young James Whistler's life. Employed to draw a map of Anacapa for the Coast and Geodetic Survey, he found it impossible to curb his talents, sketched in, for good measure, an imaginary flock of sea gulls. He was fortunately fired for this piece of inspiration, and went on to become a world-famous painter.

San Nicholas lies some fifty miles from the mainland, a wind-scoured expanse that was once the home of a tribe of hardy Indians who wrested a precarious living from the kelp beds that ring the island, and occasional springs of sweet water. Aleuts and Russians, drawn here by the abundance of fur-bearing sea otter, so decimated the tribe that in 1835 the Mexican government removed the survivors to Mission San Gabriel.

All of the survivors, that is, except one young woman. At the last moment, as the rescue ship was sailing away from the coast, she leaped into the sea and swam back to shore because her child had been left on the island.

Sixteen years afterward Captain George Nidever returned to the islands in a sailing schooner called *Peor es Nada*—Better than Nothing. A West Virginian, he had trapped through the Rockies, become a seafarer in Santa Barbara, and finally began to hunt otter—the few that remained—among the Channel Islands. It was in search of otter that he came in the early spring of 1851.

The first thing Nidever saw as he stepped ashore in a small cove was a faint yet fresh footprint in the hard sand. He found other prints moving away from the edge of the sea toward steep cliffs that sheltered the cove. He knew the story of the Lost Woman of San Nicholas and was determined to find her if the footprints proved to be hers.

But as he left the cove, following her course up the cliff, Nidever was met by the furious blast of a northwest wind. He glanced back and was alarmed to see that his schooner was heeled over, tugging at its anchor. He quickly retraced his steps and sailed away from the coast before the ship was blown ashore.

The following year he returned, still bent upon finding the lost woman. But again a heavy wind sprang up as he was on the beach, and again he was forced to run out to sea.

The next year he was back.

Nidever once more found the footprints in the cove, followed them up the cliff and across the mesa to an accumulation of rocks surrounded by a few windswept trees. Amid the rocks was a crude shelter of brush and whalebones.

The woman was frightened when he spoke to her and tried to flee, but he restrained her. She was no longer young; the black hair that fell to her waist was streaked with gray. She wore a strange garment contrived of the gleaming skins of cormorants. Her only companions were five wild dogs. Her child, it seemed, had long since died.

Nidever convinced the woman that he meant no harm, and she consented to go back with him to the Mission of Santa Barbara. And although no one there understood her language, she lived happily enough for six weeks, then suddenly died from the unaccustomed fare of fruits and meats.